

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Edgar Ter Danielyan

Address: 32 Effingham Close Sutton SM2 6AG

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I write to register my objection to the above planning application for the change of use of the former Sutton Ambulance Station at 18 Dorset Road, Belmont, from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub), together with the proposed physical extensions and increase in building height. I am a local resident whose home and daily life would be directly affected by this proposal.

My objection is that this specific site, by reason of its location, access constraints, parking context, and proximity to sensitive receptors, is unsuitable for the proposed use, and that the proposal conflicts with adopted development plan policy at national, regional, and local level.

The material planning grounds for my objection are set out below under eight headings. In each case, I identify the relevant development plan policies that are engaged.

1. Traffic Generation and Highway Safety

The proposed change of use would result in a dramatic and unacceptable intensification of vehicular traffic on Dorset Road and at its junction with the A217 (Belmont Rise). The former ambulance station generated modest, predictable vehicle movements associated with a small professional crew and emergency call-outs. By contrast, a place of worship and community hub attracting congregations would generate concentrated peak-hour traffic of an entirely different order of magnitude.

The critical characteristic of this site is that Dorset Road has a long-established traffic closure that prevents through-traffic, meaning the road functions as a cul-de-sac with vehicular access only from the A217 end. This closure has been in place for many years and is valued by residents

precisely because it protects the quiet, residential character of the street. Every vehicle visiting the proposed development must enter and exit via a single junction with the A217. The arrival and departure of a large congregation within a short period - particularly for Friday prayers, weekend events, weddings, funerals, and community gatherings - would concentrate all vehicle movements at this single pinch-point, creating queuing, congestion, and conflict with traffic on the A217. The proposal would also generate traffic at times that are entirely alien to the existing residential character of the street. Daily prayers, evening classes, weekend events, and seasonal observances such as Ramadan would produce vehicle movements early in the morning, late at night, and throughout weekends and public holidays. These are precisely the periods when residential amenity is most sensitive and when residents have a legitimate expectation of quiet enjoyment.

This ground of objection is supported by Paragraph 115(d) of the NPPF (December 2024), which requires that any significant impacts from the development on the transport network, in terms of capacity and congestion, or on highway safety, can be cost-effectively mitigated to an acceptable degree. Paragraph 116 provides that development should only be refused on highways grounds where there would be an unacceptable impact on highway safety, or the residual cumulative impacts on the road network would be severe; it is submitted that both thresholds are met here. London Plan Policy T4 requires that development proposals should not increase road danger. Sutton Local Plan Policy 24 requires transport assessments and the promotion of sustainable transport. The proposed development fundamentally conflicts with all of these policies.

2. Parking Pressure on Surrounding Residential Streets

Belmont already has a Controlled Parking Zone (CPZ), which is concrete evidence that parking pressure is a recognised and documented problem in this area. The London Borough of Sutton operates only a small number of CPZs across the entire borough, and the fact that Belmont requires one confirms that on-street parking demand already exceeds available capacity. The council's own borough-wide parking review has acknowledged that parking remains one of the issues of most concern to residents, and active consultations specifically for the Belmont area were conducted throughout 2023-2024.

The site has a Public Transport Accessibility Level (PTAL) rating of just 1b-2, which is among the lowest ratings in the transport accessibility scale. This means the area is heavily car-dependent, and the overwhelming majority of visitors to any facility on this site would arrive by private car. A congregation of 240-250 people, even allowing for car-sharing, would generate demand for well over 100 parking spaces per session. The site is approximately 0.3 acres (0.12 hectares) in area. Even after the proposed extensions, the amount of on-site parking that can realistically be provided is a small fraction of the demand that would be generated.

The inevitable consequence is that the vast majority of visitors would park on surrounding residential streets - Dorset Road, Overton Road, Linden Road, Chiltern Road, and adjoining roads - displacing residents from parking near their own homes. This overspill parking would occur both within and outside CPZ operational hours. On Fridays, weekends, evenings, and during religious festivals, parking demand would be at its highest, and much of this would fall outside CPZ enforcement hours, leaving residents with no protection.

The London Plan provides no specific maximum parking standard for F1 or F2 uses. Policy T6 and Paragraph 10.6.5 state that parking levels for such uses must be determined on a case-by-case basis, taking into account PTAL, local connectivity, and the transport context of the site. In an area with PTAL 1b-2, adequate on-site parking provision is essential. The failure to provide it is contrary to policy and would cause demonstrable harm to residential amenity.

3. Noise and Disturbance to Residential Amenity

The proposed change of use would fundamentally alter the noise environment experienced by neighbouring residential properties. A place of worship and community hub generates sustained, regular, and predictable noise from multiple sources: amplified speech, recitation, or chanting within the building; the gathering and dispersal of large congregations outside the building before and after services; the simultaneous starting, manoeuvring, and departure of dozens of vehicles; conversations and social interaction in outdoor areas; deliveries; and celebrations associated with weddings, festivals, and community events.

The site is flanked by residential properties on all sides. It is also in close proximity to Overton Park (a public recreation ground used by families and children), a primary school, Overton Grange secondary school, Sutton Bowling Club, and Belmont House Nursing Home (a 60-bed residential, nursing, and dementia care facility rated "Good" by the Care Quality Commission). The density of noise-sensitive receptors around this site is unusually high. Residents in the nursing home, many of whom are elderly or living with dementia, are particularly vulnerable to disturbance from sustained and unpredictable noise.

This ground of objection is supported by Sutton Local Plan Policy 29 (Protecting Amenity), which requires development to avoid unacceptable impacts on neighbouring amenity including noise and disturbance. London Plan Policy D14 (Noise) requires development to avoid significant adverse noise impacts on health and quality of life. London Plan Policy D13 (Agent of Change) places the onus on new noise-generating development to design in mitigation to protect existing residents. NPPF Paragraph 135(f) requires development to create places with a high standard of amenity for existing and future users. The proposed development conflicts with all of these policies.

4. Hours of Operation

Places of worship and community hubs, by their nature, operate across a wide range of hours that extend well beyond the typical working day. Daily prayers may begin before dawn and continue after dark. Evening study circles, youth groups, community meetings, and social events extend activity into late evening. Seasonal observances, particularly Ramadan, involve pre-dawn and post-sunset gatherings that would generate vehicle movements and pedestrian activity at the most sensitive hours of the night and early morning.

In addition, weddings, funerals, festivals, and special community events may take place at weekends and on public holidays, when residents have a heightened expectation of quiet enjoyment of their homes and gardens. The former ambulance station, despite being a 24-hour facility, generated no comparable external footfall, congregational noise, or visitor traffic during these sensitive periods.

Hours of operation are a specifically recognised material planning consideration. If the council is

mindful to approve this application - which for the reasons set out in this letter I submit it should not - then strictly enforceable conditions on hours of operation would be essential. However, it is submitted that the nature of the proposed use is such that the hours of activity cannot realistically be conditioned in a way that would adequately protect residential amenity, given the frequency and breadth of the activities proposed.

5. Scale, Massing, and Impact on Local Character

The proposal involves the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension and an increase in the height of part of the building. These physical alterations would transform the form, scale, and visual appearance of the building from a low-key operational garage and yard into an institutional-scale structure. The resulting building would be out of keeping with the prevailing character of Dorset Road, which is defined by semi-detached and detached family homes of a consistent domestic scale.

Belmont is a quiet, suburban, overwhelmingly residential village. Census data confirms that over 60 per cent of the land area in the immediate locality is domestic gardens, which is more than double the London average. The residential character is one of spaciousness, greenery, and low-density family housing. An institutional building with increased height and massing, together with associated signage, lighting, boundary treatment, cycle stores, and refuse enclosures, would represent an incongruous intrusion into this established residential streetscape.

NPPF Paragraph 135(c) requires development to be sympathetic to local character and history, including the surrounding built environment. Paragraph 139 states that development which is not well designed should be refused, especially where it fails to reflect local design policies and government guidance on design. Sutton Local Plan Policy 28 (Character and Design) requires development to respect and enhance the surrounding character. The council's Design of Residential Extensions Supplementary Planning Document (2006) provides further guidance on extensions in residential areas. It is submitted that the proposed extensions conflict with these policies.

6. Loss of Blue Light Emergency Service Infrastructure

The former Sutton Ambulance Station is classified as Sui Generis - a specialist use that served the community as blue light emergency service infrastructure. Its loss raises specific policy concerns at all three tiers of the development plan.

NPPF Paragraph 101 gives significant weight to the need to create, expand, or alter public service infrastructure, including the provision of facilities for blue light services. This policy direction clearly favours the retention and re-use of blue light sites for public service purposes, rather than their conversion to unrelated uses. NPPF Paragraph 98(c) directs planning authorities to guard against the unnecessary loss of valued facilities and services, particularly where this would reduce the community's ability to meet its day-to-day needs.

London Plan Policy S1 (Developing London's Social Infrastructure) states that development proposals that result in a loss of social infrastructure in an area of defined need should be refused, unless realistic re-provision plans exist or the loss is part of a wider public service transformation plan demonstrating that the facility is surplus to requirements. The applicant should be required to

provide robust evidence that the London Ambulance Service has permanently confirmed the site is surplus, that no alternative emergency or social infrastructure use of the building is viable, and that no equivalent re-provision is needed for the local area.

Sutton Local Plan Policies 20-23 (Social Infrastructure) similarly protect existing social infrastructure from loss. The Sui Generis ambulance station use classification could accommodate a range of alternative social infrastructure uses - for example, community healthcare, emergency response training, or other public services. The automatic loss of this potential to accommodate future social infrastructure needs should not be accepted without compelling justification.

7. Pedestrian Safety and Conflict

Large congregations arriving and departing simultaneously generate significant pedestrian footfall on a street that was not designed for institutional-scale visitor numbers. Dorset Road serves as a route to a primary school and is within the catchment area of Overton Grange secondary school. Families with children walk along this road daily to access these schools and Overton Park. The bowling club also attracts elderly pedestrians.

The concentration of all vehicle movements at the single Dorset Road/A217 junction, combined with large numbers of pedestrians walking to and from the proposed facility along the same narrow section of road, creates unacceptable pedestrian-vehicle conflict. This risk is heightened during periods of peak congregation attendance (Fridays, weekends, evenings, and festivals), which coincide with times when children and families are most likely to be using the park and walking to school or community activities.

NPPF Paragraph 117 requires development to minimise the scope for conflicts between pedestrians, cyclists, and vehicles, and to avoid unnecessary street clutter. NPPF Paragraph 96(b) requires places to be safe and accessible. NPPF Paragraph 102 and Footnote 44 explicitly list places of worship among locations where large numbers of people congregate, requiring heightened public safety consideration. London Plan Policy T4 requires that development proposals should not increase road danger. It is submitted that the proposed development would create unacceptable pedestrian safety risks contrary to these policies.

8. Refuse, Waste Management, and Servicing

A community hub and place of worship with regular large gatherings will generate substantially different and larger waste streams than a former ambulance station. Community meals, celebrations, weddings, and events produce significant volumes of food waste, packaging, and general refuse. The storage, containment, and collection of this waste on a constrained residential street raises material amenity concerns, including odour, vermin attraction, and visual impact for neighbouring residential properties.

The application proposes the provision of refuse stores, but no detail has been provided as to the capacity, frequency of collection, or access arrangements for collection vehicles. Given that Dorset Road is traffic-calmed and functions as a cul-de-sac, the manoeuvring of large refuse collection vehicles at the site and at the road's turning area raises practical concerns. Inadequate refuse provision would cause nuisance to neighbouring properties and is contrary to Sutton Local Plan

Policy 29 (Protecting Amenity).

Conclusion and Request

For all of the reasons set out above, I submit that the proposed development is contrary to the adopted development plan at all three tiers. It conflicts with NPPF Paragraphs 96, 98, 101, 102, 115, 116, 117, 135, and 139; London Plan Policies S1, D13, D14, T4, and T6; and Sutton Local Plan Policies 20-23, 24, 28, and 29.

The combination of a traffic-calmed cul-de-sac, an existing Controlled Parking Zone confirming pre-existing parking stress, a PTAL rating of 1b-2 ensuring high car dependency, and a dense cluster of sensitive receptors - including a primary school, a secondary school, a nursing home, a GP surgery, and a public park - renders this specific location fundamentally unsuitable for a use of this nature and intensity.

I would note that planning appeal decisions support this assessment. In the Windsor Muslim Association appeal (2021), Inspector Pipkin dismissed a proposal for a prayer hall accommodating just 30 families, finding that cumulative planning harms including highway safety and residential amenity impacts outweighed even the substantial weight given to equality considerations. In the Bearwood Road, Smethwick appeal (2020), an inspector dismissed a proposal for a mosque and community centre for approximately 250 people, citing inadequate on-site parking, unacceptable highway safety risks, parking overspill, and noise nuisance. In *Ikram v Secretary of State* (Wembley, 2019), the High Court quashed an inspector's decision allowing a mosque and community centre, finding fundamental defects in the assessment of residential amenity, parking, noise, food waste, and light pollution impacts.

I request that the council refuse this application. In the alternative, if the council is minded to approve, I request that the application be referred to the council's Planning Committee for determination rather than being decided under delegated powers, so that the significant local concerns can be heard and considered in a public forum.